HEIRSTONE CONSULTING

HERITAGE DESTINATIONS

The gate and the night

Why heritage sites draw record crowds while the land around them keeps little of what visitors spend, and what that land should hold. With a view from Egypt, Saudi Arabia and the wider region.



THE REPORT IN SIX NUMBERS

3%

A foreign adult ticket to the Grand Egyptian Museum, about US$30, as a share of the US$975 that the average international visitor spent in Egypt in 2024

+11.8%

Growth in Angkor's foreign visitors in 2017, the year its one-day pass rose 85%. Ticket revenue rose 72.5%

4.27m

Visits to Pompeii in 2024, more than the 3.86 million overnight stays recorded in the whole city of Naples

JD 90

Petra's one-day fee for a foreign visitor who is not staying overnight in Jordan, against JD 50 for one who is

18.6m

Visits to Egypt's archaeological sites and museums in 2025, 33.5% more than in 2024, not counting the Grand Egyptian Museum

2.1%

Share of Diriyah's 14 km² masterplan taken by the At-Turaif World Heritage property

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

Heirstone Consulting advises developers, sovereign and private investors, land agencies and tourism authorities across the Middle East and Africa on destinations, highest and best use, feasibility and development strategy.

This report uses public sources current in 2026: UNESCO records, site operators' published tariffs and timetables, government statistics, company disclosures and press reports that quote primary parties. Every figure is referenced in the exhibit sources and in the notes at the end.

Where we combine published figures to produce a new one, such as revenue per visitor or the ratio of a buffer zone to the property it protects, the calculation is labelled Heirstone analysis and its inputs are shown.

IN BRIEF

The great heritage sites now ration and price their gates with care. Most of what their visitors spend still lands outside the gate, where planning is weakest.

This report looks at 28 heritage sites and museums, from Giza and Petra to Pompeii and Angkor, and asks where a visitor's money goes. The ticket matters less than four other things: where the visitor arrives, how late the site stays open, whether the ticket rewards a night, and who plans the land in between.

1 The gate keeps a few per cent of what a visitor spends.

A foreign adult ticket to the Grand Egyptian Museum costs about US$30, roughly 3% of the US$975 the average international visitor spent in Egypt in 2024. Angkor earned about US$44 per foreign visitor in 2017, around 7% of Cambodia's receipts per arrival. National averages make these shares indicative, but most of a trip's spending happens beyond any one gate.

2 Price has rarely held visitors back.

When Angkor raised its one-day pass 85% in 2017, foreign visitors still grew 11.8% and ticket revenue 72.5%. The Louvre lifted its full price 29% in 2024 and lost 2% of visitors, then recovered. At Angkor, tourism businesses reported that visitors were shortening their trips.

3 Sites are shortening the visit by design.

Pompeii, the Acropolis and the Grand Egyptian Museum each admit up to 20,000 a day. The Colosseum allows 75 minutes inside, and Pompeii sells 75% of its summer capacity before 13:00. Nine of the 13 benchmark sites that publish hours close by 19:00. Pompeii's 4.27 million visits in 2024 exceeded all overnight stays in Naples.

4 Arrival points decide where the money lands.

Car parks, ticket halls and shuttles have moved off the monuments, to a new highway entrance at Giza built for 1,200 cars and 300 buses and to a visitor centre 2.4 km away at Stonehenge, and the commercial plots have moved with them. Buffer zones vary a thousandfold, and size has not decided outcomes: Liverpool lost its listing with a buffer 5.5 times its core.

5 A few sites price the night.

Petra charges JD 90 to a visitor who does not sleep in Jordan and JD 50 to one who does, with a second day for JD 5. Machu Picchu sells 1,000 tickets a day only in its gateway district, and Diriyah's ticket can be spent in Bujairi's restaurants. Elsewhere, foreign premiums of up to 22 times the local price reward nothing beyond entry.

6 The region is running two opposite experiments.

Egypt has invested at the gate and in arrival: the Grand Egyptian Museum and a new Giza entrance opened in 2025, a year of a record 19 million arrivals and 18.6 million visits to its sites and museums. Saudi Arabia has wrapped a 28.78 ha core in a 14 km^2 district at Diriyah and placed Hegra under a 22,561 km^2 planning authority, while AlUla's rooms and visitors remain below earlier targets.

WHAT TO DO

GOVERNMENTS AND LAND AGENCIES

Define and zone the land around each core before the next investment arrives. Turn the foreign premium into a reward for staying. Publish visits and nights by site.

MASTER DEVELOPERS

Treat the arrival point as the first plot. Open the evening before the hotels. Phase rooms on measured nights, and design for domestic visitors.

INVESTORS AND LENDERS

Underwrite nights per visit. Stress-test single-site gateways for a 60% fall in a year. Read the concession before the plot.

SITE OPERATORS

Use slots and multi-day passes to send time into the district. Open later. Make the ticket spendable outside the gate.

CHAPTER 1



01 Full by noon, gone by dinner

The most visited heritage sites now ration entry by the day and by the hour. That protects the monuments and shortens the visit. The rest of the visitor's day, and most of the money, goes somewhere else.

The World Heritage List held 1,273 properties in 2025, 991 of them cultural. A handful draw city-sized crowds. The Colosseum archaeological park received almost 15 million visitors in 2024 and Pompeii 4.3 million. The Forbidden City passed 19 million in 2019, the Louvre took 9.0 million in 2025 and the Taj Mahal about 6.9 million in 2024-25.

These sites have spent the past three years rationing their gates. The Acropolis has admitted at most 20,000 people a day since September 2023, in hourly slots. Pompeii introduced named tickets and a 20,000 daily limit for its 2025 season. The Grand Egyptian Museum, formally opened on 1 November 2025, sells a quota of 20,000 tickets a day online.

Caps work inside the fence. Outside it, they change the shape of the visitor's day. Arrivals bunch in the morning, visits get shorter, and the hours and nights that carry most of the spending happen wherever the visitor is staying. For many of the sites we studied, that is a city or a cruise boat some distance away.

1,273

properties on the World Heritage List in 2025, 991 of them cultural

40,000

daily cap at the Forbidden City, which sells no tickets on the day

75 min

permitted stay inside the Colosseum on a standard ticket

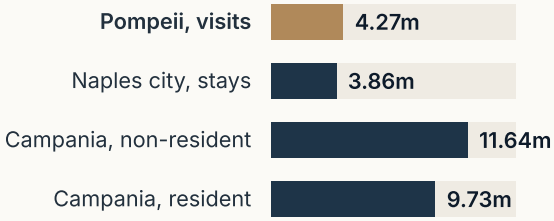
DAY-TRIPS

Pompeii records more visits in a year than the city of Naples records overnight stays

EXHIBIT 1

Pompeii's visits exceed every overnight stay recorded in the city of Naples

Visits to Pompeii and overnight stays (presenze) in Naples and Campania, 2024, millions



Source: Italian Ministry of Culture, 2024 ranking of state cultural sites, via Finestre sull'Arte (May 2025); ISTAT, I flussi turistici, anno 2024 (March 2026). Overnight stays cover all accommodation types.

In 2024 Pompeii recorded 4,267,233 visits. ISTAT counted 3,862,329 overnight stays in the municipality of Naples that year and 11.6 million stays by non-residents across Campania. Pompeii's visits equal 110% of the city's nights and 37% of the region's non-resident nights. Visits and nights are different units, but the gap is wide enough to make the point: most of Pompeii's visitors are on a day out.

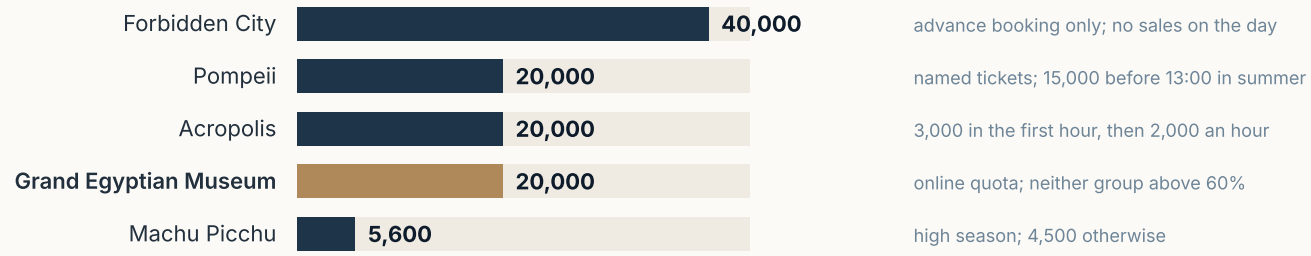
Pompeii's own capacity plan assumes as much. Between 16 March and 14 October it allows 15,000 entries from 9:00 to 13:00 and 5,000 from 13:00 to 17:30, so three quarters of the day's capacity is sold before lunch.

Venice shows the same pattern at city scale. Of its 27 million visitors in 2017, just over 10 million spent at least one night in a hotel. Since April 2024 the city has charged day-trippers an access fee on peak days, EUR 5 or EUR 10 for late registration, over 54 days in 2025. Opponents of the fee, citing the city's mobile phone data, said the first fee days of 2024 drew more visitors than comparable holidays in 2023.

EXHIBIT 2

Four of the busiest heritage sites in the benchmark cap entry at 20,000 a day or more

Maximum daily admissions under the latest published rule, visitors a day



Source: The Palace Museum (2026); Parco Archeologico di Pompei (2026); Travel News citing the Hellenic Ministry of Culture (September 2023); The New Arab citing the GEM director (November 2025); Andina citing the Peruvian Ministry of Culture (November 2025).

A cap is a ceiling on footfall and, by extension, on what the site itself can earn. It does nothing to lengthen the visit. The Acropolis lets in 3,000 people in its first hour and 2,000 in each hour after that, which spreads the crowd through the day without keeping anyone longer. Before the cap the Acropolis saw up to 23,000 visitors on its busiest days, according to the culture minister.

Machu Picchu runs the most detailed system: three circuits divided into ten routes since June 2024, with a daily limit of 4,500 that rises to 5,600 in the high season. It is also the only site in the benchmark that reserves part of its capacity for sale in its gateway town, a point we return to in Chapter 2.

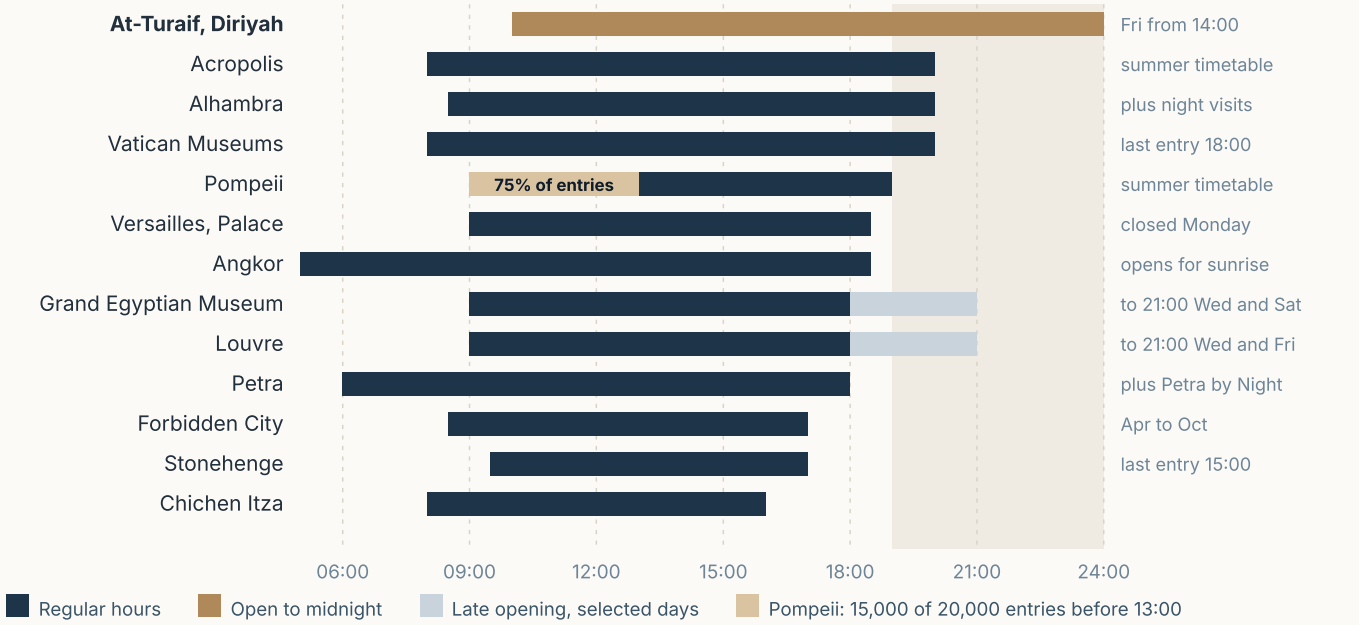
HOURS

Nine of the 13 benchmark sites that publish their hours close by 19:00. At-Turaif stays open until midnight.

EXHIBIT 3

Of the 13 sites that publish hours, only one is open every evening

Regular opening hours, summer timetable where seasonal, 2026. Pale extensions are late openings on selected days; the shaded band marks 19:00 to midnight



Source: Heirstone Heritage Site Benchmark 2026, from operators' published timetables (Bujairi/Diriyah Company, Hellenic Ministry of Culture, Patronato de la Alhambra, Musei Vaticani, Parco Archeologico di Pompei, Château de Versailles, Angkor Enterprise, Musée du Louvre, Visit Petra, The Palace Museum, English Heritage, INAH). GEM hours from Enterprise (November 2025).

Opening hours are a land-use decision as much as an operational one. A site that closes at 17:00 sends its visitors back to their hotels, or to their coaches, before dinner. The Louvre and the Grand Egyptian Museum open late on two evenings a week; the Alhambra and Petra sell separate night visits, and Giza and Karnak stage sound and light shows every evening.

At-Turaif in Diriyah is the exception. It opens from 10:00 to midnight, Saturday to Thursday, and from 14:00 on Fridays, with last entry at 23:00. Bujairi Terrace, beside it, has more than 20 restaurants and cafés and received over a million visitors in its first six months.

Inside the gate, sites are also limiting how long people stay. A standard Colosseum ticket allows 75 minutes inside the amphitheatre. Since 2019 the Taj Mahal has charged visitors extra for staying more than three hours. The standard Hegra Day Tour is a guided bus tour of two to three hours, in buses of up to 45 people.

At Angkor, where a pass can cover a week, 63.6% of the tickets sold in 2017 were for a single day and 1% for seven days. Horwath HTL puts the average stay in Siem Reap at two to three nights, whatever the source market.

3 hours

standard stay at the Taj Mahal since 2019; longer visits pay extra

2-3 hours

length of the guided Hegra Day Tour, from SAR 95

63.6%

of Angkor tickets sold in 2017 were one-day passes

CHAPTER 2

02 What a ticket earns

Heritage tickets have become dearer, and in much of the region foreign visitors pay many times the local price. The gate still keeps a small share of what a visitor spends.

A heritage ticket is one of the few prices at a destination that the site sets and keeps. It is also a small one. Ticketing at the Louvre brings in more than EUR 100m a year against a budget above EUR 300m; a state subsidy of about EUR 93m in 2024, patronage and other income make up the rest. On the minimum ticketing figure that is about EUR 11.5 per visitor in 2024, about half the EUR 22 full price.

Angkor earned US$46.6 for each foreign ticket it sold in 2023, the same as in 2018. The Taj Mahal, the Archaeological Survey of India's top earner in each of the five years to 2023-24, took INR 297 crore from about 22 million visitors over that period.

Exhibit 4 sets the ticket against what international visitors spend in the country as a whole. At the Grand Egyptian Museum, at Angkor and at Hegra, it equals about 2% to 7% of average spending per arrival. The shares are indicative, since national averages include visitors who never see the site and others who see several. Most of a trip's spending goes on beds, meals, other sites, transport and shopping; how much lands near the site depends on what the land around it offers.

EXHIBIT 4

At three flagship sites, the ticket equals about 2% to 7% of what the average international visitor spends in the country

Main foreign adult ticket, or ticket revenue per foreign visitor, as a share of international tourism spending per arrival; latest year with both figures. Indicative: national averages include visitors who do not see the site

	Ticket		Average spend per international arrival = 100%
Egypt, 2024 Grand Egyptian Museum	**3.1%**	foreign adult ticket, about US$30	**US$975 per arrival**
Cambodia, 2017 Angkor	**6.8%**	ticket revenue per foreign visitor, US$44	**US$648 per arrival**
Saudi Arabia, 2024 Hegra	**1.7%**	Hegra Day Tour, from SAR 95	**SAR 5,673 per inbound tourist**

Source: The New Arab (November 2025); Ministry of Tourism and Antiquities via Ecofin (January 2026); Angkor Enterprise via Bangkok Post (January 2018); Cambodia Ministry of Tourism via B2B Cambodia (March 2018) and Tourism Statistics Report (December 2017); Experience AlUla (2026); Saudi Ministry of Tourism via Argaam (June 2025). Years and bases differ by country; the Saudi average covers all inbound tourists, including religious visitors. **Heirstone analysis.**

c.EUR 11.5

Louvre ticketing income per visitor, 2024: more than EUR 100m over 8.7 million visitors

US$46.6

Angkor ticket revenue per foreign visitor in both 2018 and 2023

S/ 119

average yield per Machu Picchu ticket, 3 to 27 August 2024 (S/ 13.0m from 109,501 tickets)

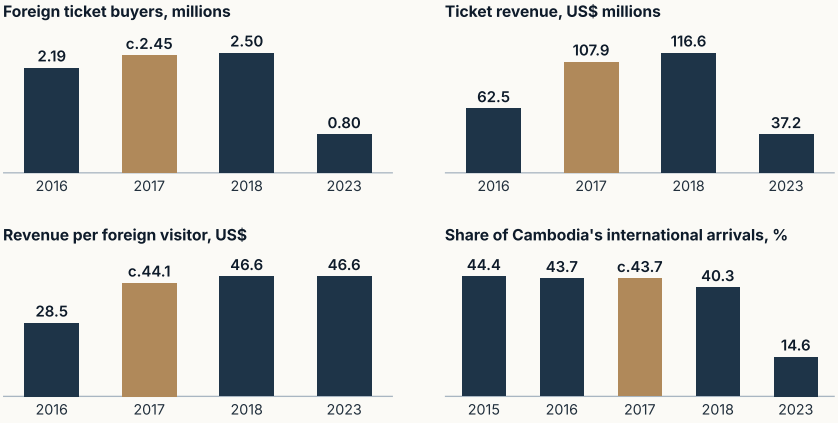
PRICE

When Angkor nearly doubled its one-day price in 2017, visitors kept coming and tourism businesses reported shorter trips

EXHIBIT 5

Angkor's price rise lifted revenue per foreign visitor from US$28.5 to US$46.6; the later fall in volume left it unchanged

Angkor Archaeological Park: foreign ticket buyers, ticket revenue and revenue per visitor, 2016 to 2023; share of Cambodia's international arrivals, 2015 to 2023. Gold marks 2017, the first year of the new prices



Source: Angkor Enterprise via Bangkok Post (2016, January 2018), B2B Cambodia (January 2019) and Khmer Times/Vietstock (March 2024); Cambodia Ministry of Tourism, Tourism Statistics Reports (2016, 2017, 2018 and 2023). 2017 buyers estimated from reported 11.8% growth; 2019 omitted because sources conflict. **Heirstone analysis.**

+85%

rise in the one-day pass on 1 February 2017, from US$20 to US$37. The three-day pass rose 55% and the seven-day pass 20%

US$10.3

price per day of a seven-day pass, against US$37 for a single day

2.1%

Koh Ker temple and Chong Kneas boat-trip ticket revenue together, as a share of Angkor's, January to November 2024

On 1 February 2017 Angkor's one-day pass rose from US$20 to US$37, the three-day pass from US$40 to US$62 and the seven-day pass from US$60 to US$72. Ticket revenue rose 72.5% that year, to US$107.9m, and foreign visitors still grew 11.8%. Revenue per foreign visitor went from about US$28.5 in 2016 to US$46.6 in 2018.

Two details matter for the land around the temples. The rise was steepest on the shortest visit, so the tariff now favours longer stays. Yet 63.6% of the tickets sold in 2017 were one-day passes and 1% were for seven days, and the Cambodia National Tourism Alliance said businesses were seeing tourists shorten their trips. Visitors paid the higher price at the gate and, by the industry's account, spent fewer days in Cambodia.

The second lesson came after 2020. In 2023 Angkor sold 798,069 foreign tickets, a third of its 2018 level, while Cambodia's arrivals had recovered to 5.45 million. Angkor's share of the country's arrivals fell from 44% in 2015 to 15%. Revenue per visitor did not move. The gate price did nothing for Siem Reap's two weak points, volume and length of stay.

Satellite sites barely register. Between January and November 2024 Koh Ker's tickets and the Chong Kneas boat trips together earned about US$0.9m, against US$41.9m at Angkor. A new international airport east of Siem Reap was due to open at the end of 2023, with capacity for 7 million passengers a year in its first phase; in 2024 Horwath HTL still put the average stay at two to three nights.

> *Visitors paid the higher price at the gate. By the industry's account, they spent fewer days in the country.*

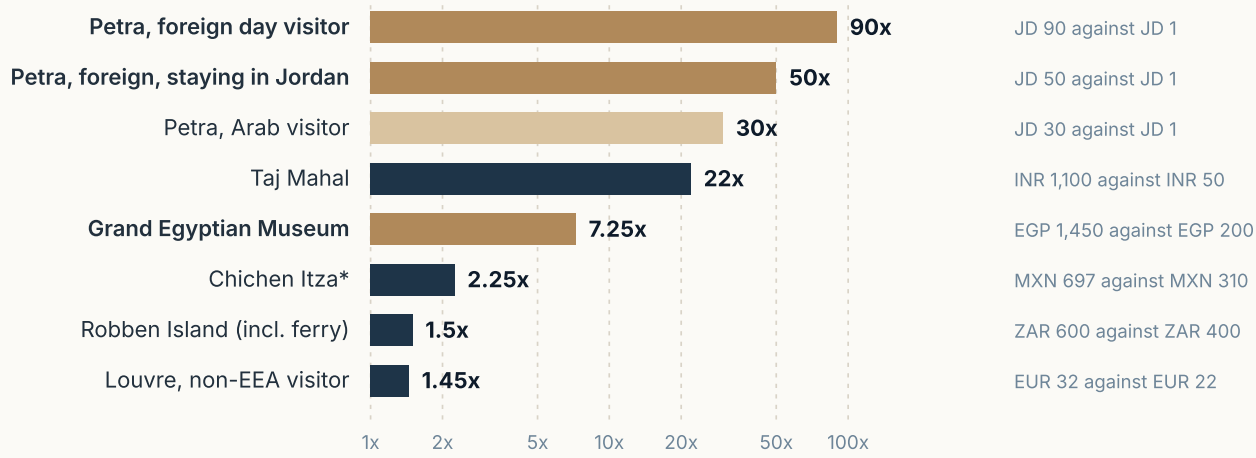
WHO PAYS

In the region, foreign premiums run from 7.25 to 90 times the local price. Only Petra ties the premium to a night's stay.

EXHIBIT 6

Foreign visitors pay between 1.45 and 90 times the local price at sites with two-tier tariffs

Foreign adult ticket as a multiple of the national adult ticket, 2025-26, log scale. Gold: Middle East sites



Source: Visit Petra, Petra Development and Tourism Region Authority (2026); Taj Mahal official site (2026); The New Arab (November 2025); INAH (2026); Robben Island Museum (2026); Musée du Louvre (2026). *Assumes nationals also pay the federal INAH fee of MXN 105. **Heirstone analysis.**

Two-tier pricing is long established in the region and now spreading in Europe. A foreign adult pays EGP 1,450 at the Grand Egyptian Museum against EGP 200 for an Egyptian; at Petra the foreign price is up to 90 times the Jordanian one. From 14 January 2026 the Louvre charges visitors from outside the European Economic Area EUR 32 against EUR 22, and expects EUR 15m to 20m a year more. Versailles has added EUR 3 for non-EEA visitors, worth an estimated EUR 9.3m a year.

In Egypt the foreign price has risen modestly in dollar terms. When the museum's tariff was first announced in January 2020, the foreign ticket was EGP 400, then about US$25, according to Egyptian Streets. It was EGP 1,200 in the trial opening of August 2024 and EGP 1,450, about US$30, in November 2025, about 20% more in dollars over the period.

The Egyptian adult price was lowered from EGP 350 to EGP 200 between August 2024 and November 2025. Masrawy reported EGP 1,590 in April 2026, when the board approved a further US$5 for foreigners from 1 November 2026. Entry to the interior of the Great Pyramid rose 67% for foreigners, to EGP 1,500, from January 2025.

The Louvre's experience suggests that demand at a unique site absorbs such increases. It raised its full price from EUR 17 to EUR 22 in January 2024; visitors fell 2% in a year also shaped by the Paris Olympics, and recovered to 9.0 million in 2025.

These premiums raise revenue at the gate. With one exception they are set by nationality or residence alone, and reward nothing the visitor does after leaving. The exception is Petra, where the foreign price depends on whether the visitor sleeps in Jordan.

+20%

rise in the GEM foreign ticket in US dollars, from about US$25 when the tariff was announced in 2020 to about US$30 in 2025

+50%

Acropolis general ticket, EUR 20 to EUR 30 from April 2025, as announced in 2023 (AP); the ministry's Odysseus portal still listed EUR 20 in 2026

EUR 5,000

for a private Acropolis visit outside opening hours, for up to five people

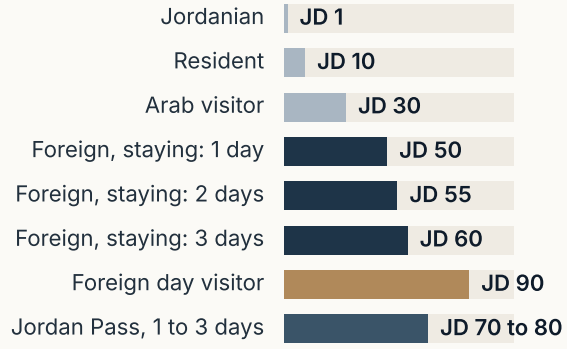
CONDITIONS

A few sites price the night. Petra charges a day-tripper 80% more, and sells a second day for JD 5.

EXHIBIT 7

Petra's tariff rewards a night in Jordan and a second day at the site

Petra entry fees by visitor category and length of visit, Jordanian dinars, 2026. Staying: staying overnight anywhere in Jordan



Source: Visit Petra, Petra Development and Tourism Region Authority (2026); Jordan Pass, prices (2026). The Jordan Pass waives the visa fee for visitors who buy it before arrival and stay at least two nights.

Petra's published tariff is the clearest stay-capture instrument we found. A foreign visitor staying overnight anywhere in Jordan pays JD 50 for one day, JD 55 for two and JD 60 for three. A visitor who is not staying overnight pays JD 90 for a single day. The day-tripper's premium is 80%; the second day costs a tenth of the first.

The Jordan Pass goes further. At JD 70, 75 or 80 for one, two or three days at Petra, it also waives the tourist visa fee, provided the pass is bought before arrival and the visitor stays at least two nights.

Other sites use quotas and bundles. Machu Picchu sells 1,000 of its daily tickets only in person in the Machupicchu district, between 18% and 22% of the daily limit, so part of its demand must reach the town before it reaches the citadel. Diriyah's access ticket can be spent in Bujairi's cafés and restaurants.

EXHIBIT 8

Eight ways sites tie entry to time spent nearby

Published ticketing and access instruments that reward staying, spending or returning, 2024-26

INSTRUMENT	WHERE	TERMS	WHAT IT REWARDS
Stay-conditional price	Petra	JD 90 for a one-day visitor not staying in Jordan; JD 50 for one who is	A night anywhere in Jordan
Visa linked to nights	Jordan Pass	Visa fee waived if the pass is bought before arrival and the stay is two nights or more	Two nights in the country
Local sale quota	Machu Picchu	1,000 tickets a day sold only in person in the Machupicchu district	A night in Aguas Calientes
Ticket as credit	Diriyah Access	Entry ticket redeemable at Bujairi cafés and restaurants	A meal beside the site
Multi-day pass	Angkor	US$37, US$62 and US$72 for one, three and seven days	Return visits on later days
Multi-site pass	Pompeii	EUR 30 for three days including satellite sites, against EUR 25 for one day	A second day in the area
Day-tripper levy	Venice	EUR 5 access fee, EUR 10 for late registrants, on 54 peak days in 2025	Staying overnight in the city
Out-of-hours premium	Acropolis	EUR 5,000 for a private visit for up to five people	Early and late hours at a premium

Source: Visit Petra (2026); Jordan Pass (2026); Andina citing Ministerial Resolution 404-2024-MC (April 2025); Bujairi/Diriyah Company ticketing (2026); Angkor Enterprise (2026); Parco Archeologico di Pompei (2026); AP (April 2025); AP via Boston Globe (December 2023).

CHAPTER 3

03 The Heirstone Heritage Site Benchmark

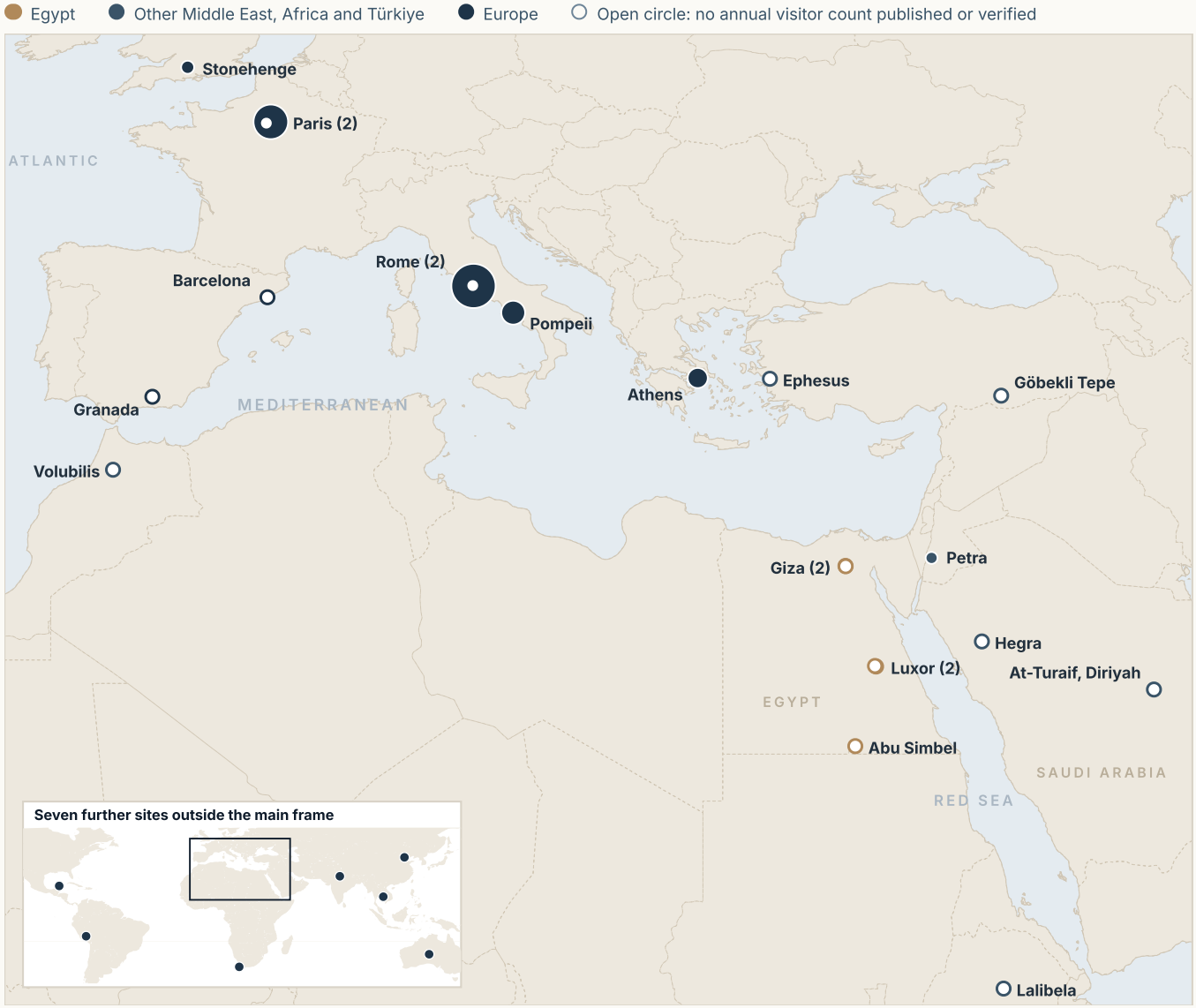
We compiled public data on 28 heritage sites and museums: five in Egypt, eight elsewhere in the Middle East, Africa and Türkiye, nine in Europe and six in Asia, the Americas and Oceania. For each we record the latest published visitor count, the foreign adult ticket and any local price, caps and timed entry, opening hours, visitor facilities and investment, and the managing body. From UNESCO's records we take the area of each property and its buffer zone. Visitor years run from 2017 to 2025, so comparisons of volume need care, and we have not converted currencies.

Counting practice varies. Egypt publishes a national total for its archaeological sites and museums, 18.6 million visits in 2025, a third more than in 2024; Stonehenge publishes its own figure to the visit, 1,253,397 in 2025. For 11 of the 28 sites, in six countries, we found no site-level annual count, and for six more we could not verify the figures in circulation.

EXHIBIT 9

The benchmark: 21 sites from the Atlantic to the Gulf, and seven further afield

Heirstone Heritage Site Benchmark 2026. Circle area scales with the latest published annual visitors; numbers in brackets are sites in the same city



Source: Heirstone Heritage Site Benchmark 2026 (pages 12 and 13). Coordinates from UNESCO World Heritage Centre and GeoNames. Inset: Robben Island, Taj Mahal, Angkor, Forbidden City, Uluru, Machu Picchu and Chichen Itza.

THE BENCHMARK

Twenty-eight heritage sites, one table

EXHIBIT 10

Caps cluster at 20,000 a day, foreign premiums are steepest in the region, and buffer zones vary a thousandfold

Latest published figures. Local price: the national adult rate where a two-tier tariff exists; single: one general adult price. Buffer ratio: UNESCO buffer zone area divided by property area. n/p: not published. n/v: not verified. n/c: not captured in our research. *Single travel-guide, tour-operator or press source

SITE	COUNTRY	VISITORS (YEAR)	FOREIGN ADULT TICKET	LOCAL PRICE	ENTRY CONTROLS	BUFFER RATIO	ARRIVAL, FACILITIES, INVESTMENT	MANAGED BY
EGYPT								
Grand Egyptian Museum	Egypt	12,000 to 19,000 a day reported (2025)	EGP 1,450 (2025); EGP 1,590 reported (2026)*	EGP 200	20,000 a day online; timed slots	not inscribed	Over US$1bn reported; 50 ha, c.2 km from the pyramids	GEM board
Giza plateau	Egypt	Not published (press: 2.5m)	Great Pyramid interior EGP 1,500	n/v	None found	being defined	Highway entrance (2025) for 1,200 cars, 300 buses	MoTA; OPE
Karnak	Egypt	Not published	EGP 600 (2026)*	n/v	None found	0.06x	Avenue of Sphinxes reopened 2021	MoTA
Valley of the Kings	Egypt	Not published	EGP 750, more for premium tombs*	n/v	Premium tombs sold separately	0.06x	n/v	MoTA
Abu Simbel	Egypt	Not published	n/v	n/v	None found	n/p	Own airport; sound and light show	MoTA
MIDDLE EAST, AFRICA AND TÜRKIYE								
Petra	Jordan	582,550 (2025)	JD 50 staying; JD 90 day visitor	JD 1	None found	n/p	Visitor centre, e-carts; Wadi Musa c.3.7 km	PDTRA
Hegra	Saudi Arabia	Not published (AlUla: 320,000 in 2025)	SAR 95 tour (from)	n/v	Guided tours; buses of up to 45	1.02x	Tours from Winter Park	RCU
At-Turaif	Saudi Arabia	3.6m with Bujairi, Dec 2022 to mid-2025	n/p; spendable at Bujairi	n/p	Subject to availability	8.27x	Inside 14 km² masterplan	Diriyah Co.
Volubilis	Morocco	Not published	n/v	n/v	n/v	100x	Beside Moulay Idriss Zerhoun	n/v
Lalibela	Ethiopia	Not published	n/v	n/v	n/v	n/c	Temporary shelters over churches	ARCCH, Church
Robben Island	South Africa	Not published	ZAR 600 incl. ferry	ZAR 400	Four ferries a day	sea, 1 nm	Ferry from Cape Town	RIM
Ephesus	Türkiye	Not published	n/v	n/v	n/v	1.88x	Coach park proposals	MoCT
Göbekli Tepe	Türkiye	Not published	n/v	n/v	n/v	3.66x	Railway planned nearby	State
ASIA, THE AMERICAS AND OCEANIA								
Angkor	Cambodia	798,069 foreign (2023); 2.5m (2018)	US$37, 62 or 72 for 1, 3 or 7 days	n/v	None found	zoned by decree	New airport (end-2023)	APSARA
Taj Mahal	India	c.6.9m (FY2024-25)	INR 1,100 (+200 mausoleum)	INR 50	Three-hour limit	n/c	10,400 km² pollution-control zone	ASI
Forbidden City	China	Over 19m (2019)	CNY 60 (Apr to Oct)	single	40,000 a day; no sales on the day	1.80x	n/v	Palace Museum
Machu Picchu	Peru	1.41m (2017)	US$60 (reported)*	S/ 64	5,600 a day at peak; 10 routes	>1x	1,000 tickets a day sold in town	MoC Peru
Chichen Itza	Mexico	n/v	MXN 697	MXN 310	None found	n/c	Road via Pisté; site management plan	INAH, Yucatán
Uluru-Kata Tjuta	Australia	n/v	AUD 38 for three days	n/v	None; climb closed 2019	n/p	Beds and airport outside the park	Joint board

Source: Heirstone Heritage Site Benchmark 2026, from UNESCO World Heritage Centre property records; operators' tariffs and timetables; ministries and statistics offices; press reports quoting primary sources (see notes). MoTA: Ministry of Tourism and Antiquities. OPE: Orascom Pyramids Entertainment (visitor services). PDTRA: Petra Development and Tourism Region Authority. RCU: Royal Commission for AlUla. ARCCH: Ethiopian heritage authority. RIM: Robben Island Museum. MoCT: Ministry of Culture and Tourism. ASI: Archaeological Survey of India. INAH: National Institute of Anthropology and History. Ratios are **Heirstone analysis.** Europe overleaf.

THE BENCHMARK, CONTINUED

EXHIBIT 10, CONTINUED

SITE	COUNTRY	VISITORS (YEAR)	FOREIGN ADULT TICKET	LOCAL PRICE	ENTRY CONTROLS	BUFFER RATIO	ARRIVAL, FACILITIES, INVESTMENT	MANAGED BY
EUROPE								
Louvre	France	9.0m (2025)	EUR 32 non-EEA (2026)	EUR 22 EEA	Time slots recommended	n/c	Renovation of over EUR 1bn planned	Musée du Louvre
Versailles	France	n/v	EUR 35 estate pass	n/v	Timed slot, palace only	n/c	Grand Versailles programme, 2003	Public body
Acropolis	Greece	Over 3m (2022)	EUR 30 (2025)†	single	20,000 a day, hourly slots	38.4x	Museum about 300 m away	Ministry of Culture
Pompeii	Italy	4.27m (2024)	EUR 25; EUR 20 city only	single	20,000 a day; named tickets	18.2x	Grande Progetto Pompei, 2012	Archaeological park
Colosseum, Forum, Palatine	Italy	14.7m whole park (2024)	EUR 18	single	Fixed slot; 75 minutes inside	n/c	EUR 25m sponsored restoration	Archaeological park
Alhambra	Spain	n/v	EUR 22.27	single	Timed palace entry	0.15x	Night visits	Patronato
Sagrada Família	Spain	n/v	EUR 26; EUR 36 with towers	single	n/v	n/c	Ticket income funds construction	Junta Constructora
Vatican Museums	Vatican City	n/v	EUR 20 + EUR 5 booking	single	n/v	n/c	n/v	Holy See
Stonehenge	UK	1,253,397 (2025)	n/c	n/c	All-day tickets	n/c	Visitor centre 2.4 km away, GBP 27m	English Heritage

Source: Heirstone Heritage Site Benchmark 2026. Musée du Louvre; Château de Versailles; Hellenic Ministry of Culture and AP († EUR 30 from April 2025 as announced in 2023 (AP) and reported in 2025; the ministry's Odysseus portal still listed EUR 20 in 2026); Parco Archeologico di Pompei; Parco archeologico del Colosseo; Patronato de la Alhambra; Sagrada Família; Musei Vaticani; ALVA and English Heritage; Italian Ministry of Culture via Geopop and Finestre sull'Arte; L'Echo touristique (November 2025); UNESCO World Heritage Centre.

READING THE BENCHMARK

Six things the table shows

Caps cluster at 20,000 a day.

Pompeii, the Acropolis and the Grand Egyptian Museum all stop at 20,000; the Forbidden City at 40,000. At these sites the number of visitors is now set by policy as much as by demand, which makes the yield per visitor, inside and outside the gate, the variable that matters.

The steepest foreign premiums are in the region.

Petra charges foreigners 50 to 90 times the Jordanian price, the Taj Mahal 22 times and the Grand Egyptian Museum 7.25 times. Europe is starting to follow, with non-EEA surcharges at the Louvre and Versailles from 2026.

Buffer zones vary by three orders of magnitude.

Volubilis sits in a buffer 100 times its area, the Acropolis 38 times and Pompeii 18 times; At-Turaif's is eight times its area and Hegra's about the same size. Egypt is working on both of its great properties, delineating a buffer for Memphis and its Necropolis and working to extend Thebes to take in the Avenue of Sphinxes.

Arrival is where the money has gone.

Stonehenge, the Acropolis Museum, the Grand Egyptian Museum, Giza's new entrance, Hegra's Winter Park and the Louvre's renovation, put at more than EUR 1bn, are all investments in how visitors arrive. Very few sites have invested in what visitors do after they leave.

Most gates close before the evening.

Nine of the 13 sites with published hours close by 19:00 on a normal day. At-Turaif, open until midnight, is the only one that stays open every evening (Exhibit 3).

Counting is uneven.

Stonehenge publishes its visits to the last one, and Egypt a national total for its sites and museums. For 11 of the 28 sites, in six countries, we found no site-level annual count, and six more could not be verified. Without one, a gateway district has to be sized from proxies such as hotel nights.

CHAPTER 4

04

The land between the gate and the bed

Around every heritage site, land does three jobs. It protects the setting, it receives the visitor and it hosts the night. Most plans concentrate on the first; visitor spending depends on the second and third.

UNESCO's tool for the land around a World Heritage property is the buffer zone, an area with planning controls that protect the property's setting. Their rules govern what may not be built near a monument; they rarely set out what the surrounding land is for.

The second job, receiving the visitor, has moved. Site managers have pulled car parks, ticket halls and interpretation away from the monuments: to a replica cave at Lascaux in 1983, 2.4 km away at Stonehenge in 2013, and to a new entrance on the Fayoum Highway at Giza in 2025. Each move creates an arrival point with its own land, traffic and commercial potential, and takes footfall away from the frontage that served the old entrance.

The third job, hosting the night, falls to gateway towns. Some are small towns beside a single site, such as Wadi Musa, about 3.7 km from Petra in a straight line. Others are cities that would exist anyway, such as Siem Reap and Luxor. A few, at AlUla and Diriyah, are being planned now.

> *Buffer zones say what should not happen near a monument. They say little about what should.*



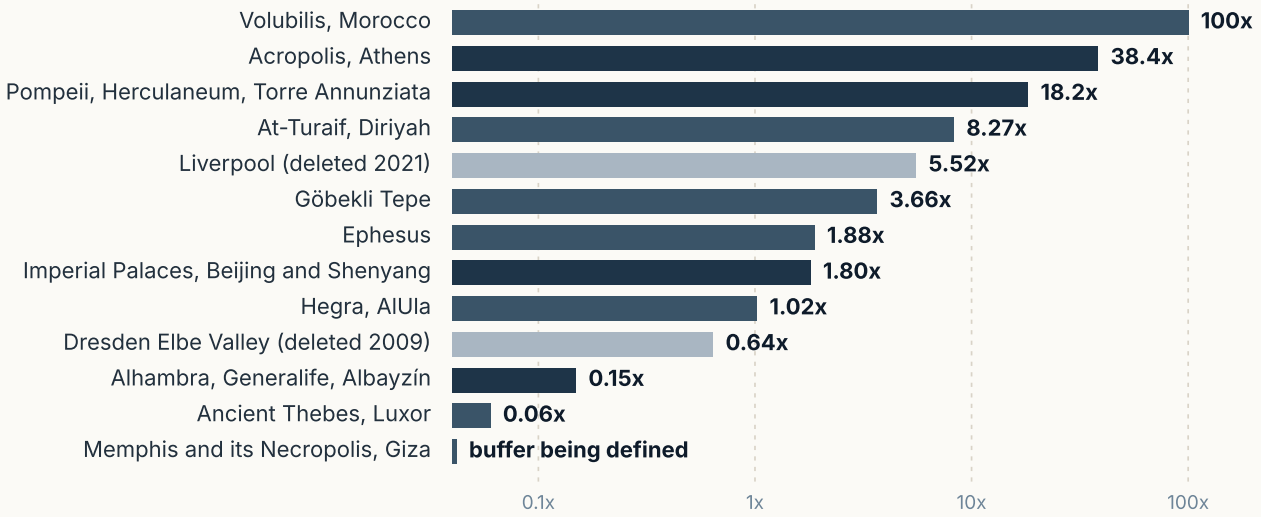
SETTING

Buffer zones range from a fraction of the property to 100 times it, and size has not decided outcomes

EXHIBIT 11

Liverpool lost its listing with a buffer 5.5 times its area, larger than most in this set

Buffer zone area as a multiple of the inscribed property area, UNESCO records, log scale. Grey: properties deleted from the World Heritage List

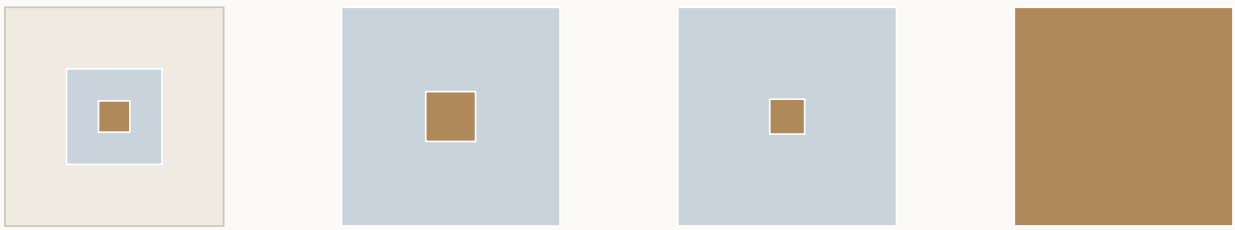


Source: UNESCO World Heritage Centre property records (accessed 2026). Imperial Palaces combines the Beijing and Shenyang components. **Heirstone analysis.**

EXHIBIT 12

Small cores with planned surroundings, and one very large core whose setting is now being planned

Inscribed property (gold), buffer zone (blue-grey) and surrounding masterplan (sand), hectares. Each panel is drawn to its own scale



At-Turaif, Diriyah
Property 28.78 ha
Buffer 237.95 ha
Masterplan 1,400 ha
Property = 2.1% of district

Pompeii
Property 98.05 ha
Buffer 1,788.79 ha
Property = 5.2% of total

Acropolis
Property 3.04 ha
Buffer 116.71 ha
Property = 2.5% of total

Memphis and its Necropolis
Property 16,358.52 ha
Buffer being defined
Plateau master plan under way

Source: UNESCO World Heritage Centre; Diriyah Company, masterplan (2026). The Diriyah masterplan area is assumed to include the property and buffer. **Heirstone analysis.**

Liverpool shows the limit of the buffer as a safeguard. Its 136 ha property had a buffer of 750.5 ha, 5.5 times its size, when the World Heritage Committee deleted it in July 2021. UNESCO's record points to the site itself: the city council granted planning permission for a development scheme there in March 2012, and the Committee placed Liverpool on the List of World Heritage in Danger that June. Dresden lost its listing in 2009 over a four-lane bridge built through the heart of the inscribed valley.

Egypt's two largest properties are on a different scale. Memphis and its Necropolis covers 16,358.52 ha from Giza to Dahshur, and UNESCO records that the ministry is delineating a buffer zone for it and that a Giza Plateau Master Plan is under way. Ancient Thebes covers 7,390.16 ha with a buffer of 443.55 ha; its management plan is being prepared, and Egypt is working to extend the property to take in the Avenue of Sphinxes.

ARRIVAL AND THE GATEWAY TOWN

As site managers move the arrival point away from the monument, the commercial plots follow it

EXHIBIT 13

Eight arrival points built away from the monuments they serve

Distance, opening, capital cost and content of off-site visitor facilities and last-mile systems

ARRIVAL POINT	DISTANCE FROM MONUMENT	OPENED	COST	WHAT IT HOLDS
Lascaux II replica	n/p	1983	n/p	Replica cave; 270,000 visitors a year before 2016
Acropolis Museum	about 300 m	2009	n/p	14,000 m² of exhibition space on a 23,000 m² site
Lascaux IV	foot of the hill	2016	EUR 57m (EU EUR 12m)	8,084 m² building planned for 400,000 visitors a year: EUR 7,050 per m², EUR 142.5 per planned annual visitor
Grand Egyptian Museum	about 2 km	2025	over US$1bn (reported)	50 ha site; 81,000 m² of permanent galleries
Stonehenge visitor centre	2.4 km (1.5 miles)	2013	GBP 27m (lottery GBP 10m)	500 cars and 30 coaches; ten-minute shuttle; road beside the stones closed and grassed
Petra visitor centre	Wadi Musa, c.3.7 km	e-carts 2021	n/p	Ten five-seat e-carts to the Treasury replaced 12 two-seat carriages; JD 25 return, 75% of income to the owners' association
Giza, Fayoum Highway entrance	south of the pyramids	2025 (trial)	EGP 1.5bn to 2bn (operator programme)	Designed for 1,200 cars, 300 buses and 12 ticket windows; welcome centre planned with shops, cafés and a cinema; 45+ electric buses
Hegra, Winter Park	n/p (Hegra is c.20 km from AlUla town)	n/p	n/p	Departure point for guided tours, up to 45 people a bus

Source: English Heritage (2013); European Commission, Regional Policy (Lascaux IV); Banque des Territoires; Acropolis Museum (2026); Ahram Online (2025); Al Gomhuria (April 2025); GeoNames (2026); AFP via Qantara (November 2021); Business Monthly, AmCham Egypt; Amwal Al Ghad; Egyptian Streets (December 2024, April 2025); Enterprise (June 2026); Euronews (April 2025); Experience AlUla (2026). Giza cost is the operator's cumulative programme; press figures range from US$19m to US$51m depending on scope. Distances for the GEM, Wadi Musa and Hegra are straight lines between GeoNames positions; these and the per-m² and per-visitor figures for Lascaux IV are **Heirstone analysis.**

EXHIBIT 14

Gateway towns sit between about 3 and 20 km from the monuments they serve

Straight-line distance from the monument to the centre of its main gateway town, kilometres, with the link between them



Source: GeoNames positions (accessed 2026), with UNESCO World Heritage Centre for Hegra; Andina (September 2025); AFP via Qantara (November 2021); Horwath HTL (September 2024); Royal Commission for AlUla (April 2021). Distances are **Heirstone analysis.**

Aguas Calientes, the town below Machu Picchu, lies about 2.7 km from the citadel in a straight line, and buses climb the Hiram Bingham road between them. The operator that had run those buses for 30 years stopped in September 2025; a temporary operator began with 18 buses against a route limit of 24.

At the other end of the scale, AlUla town lies about 20 km from Hegra, and the Royal Commission plans a population of 130,000 by 2035 alongside 2 million visitors a year, about 15 visitors per resident. A gateway with more residents per visitor can support schools, shops and services all year, which matters when visitor numbers fall.

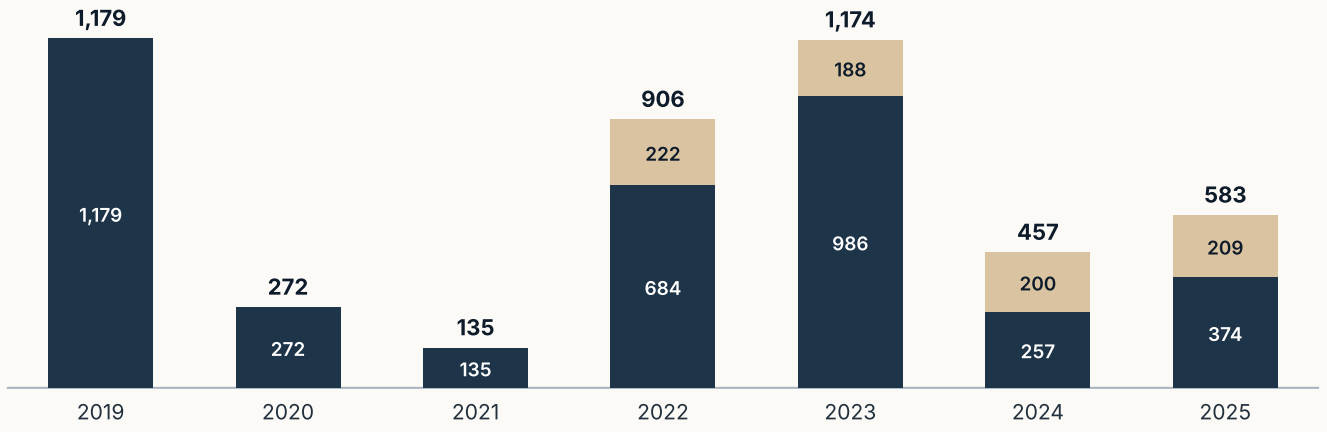
RESILIENCE

Petra lost 61% of its visitors in 2024, the risk carried by any gateway town that depends on one site

EXHIBIT 15

Petra's foreign visits fell 74% in 2024; other visitors held at about 200,000 a year

Petra visitors, thousands: foreign (navy) and other visitors, total less foreign (sand). Split not published before 2022



Source: Petra Development and Tourism Region Authority via Jordan News (February 2026) and Al-Monitor (August 2025). **Heirstone analysis** for other visitors.

Petra received 1,174,137 visitors in 2023 and 457,215 in 2024. Foreign visits fell from 985,696 to 257,284, as regional travel demand dropped. The rest of the total barely moved: about 188,000 in 2023, 200,000 in 2024 and 209,000 in 2025. By 2025 foreign visits had recovered to 373,752, 32% of the 1,179,000 recorded in 2019. According to the Petra authority, as reported by Al-Monitor, 32 hotels in the region closed and nearly 700 people lost their jobs.

Angkor's fall was slower and has lasted longer. Its share of Cambodia's arrivals dropped from 44% to 15% between 2015 and 2023, even as national arrivals recovered.

Domestic demand is the steadier base. At Siem Reap Angkor, Cambodian visitors outnumbered foreigners by six to one in the first eight months of 2023: 2,998,895 against 498,513. In 2024, 72% of AlUla's visitors were Saudi. Saudi Arabia counted 86.2 million domestic tourists that year against 29.7 million inbound, although each inbound tourist spent about 4.2 times as much, SAR 5,673 against SAR 1,338.

For the land around a site, the implication is practical. Size the first phase of rooms for a bad year, keep later phases flexible, and design the gateway district so that residents and domestic visitors use it in every season.

-61%

fall in Petra's total visitors between 2023 and 2024

6:1

domestic to foreign visitors at Siem Reap Angkor, January to August 2023

32

hotels closed in the Petra region in the downturn, according to the Petra authority via Al-Monitor

CHAPTER 5

05 The Heirstone Spend Capture Scorecard

Five tests of whether the land around a heritage site can keep the visitor's money. Each is scored from published terms, so any site can be scored the same way.

	TEST	WHAT IT ASKS, AND HOW IT IS SCORED	EVIDENCE IN THE BENCHMARK
1	Arrival	The visit starts at a planned arrival point, off the monument, with room for services. 2: an arrival centre or hub with documented services. 1: arrival through an adjacent town, station or museum. 0: none found.	Stonehenge, Giza's new entrance, Hegra's Winter Park, Uluru's Yulara
2	Hours	The site is open into the evening. 2: open past 21:00 every day, or a scheduled night programme. 1: late opening on some days, or a window of 12 hours or more. 0: otherwise, or not published.	At-Turaif to midnight; Petra by Night; sound and light at Giza, Karnak and Chichen Itza; nine of 13 sites close by 19:00
3	Night	The ticket rewards staying in the area. 2: price or ticket allocation conditional on staying or buying locally. 1: multi-day passes. 0: single-visit tickets only.	Petra's JD 90 and JD 50; Machu Picchu's 1,000 district tickets
4	Link	Ticket value or gate revenue reaches the land around the site. 2: the ticket can be spent in adjacent businesses. 1: a published share of gate or last-mile revenue goes to local operators or local government. 0: none found.	Diriyah's Bujairi credit; Petra's e-cart split; Chichen Itza's state fee
5	Land	The land around the core is planned as one. 2: a buffer at least as large as the property, or one authority planning the surrounding land. 1: a smaller buffer, or a plan in preparation. 0: no buffer and no comprehensive plan.	Diriyah Company, the Royal Commission for AlUla, APSARA at Angkor

The first two tests concern the visitor's day: where it starts and how long it can run. The third and fourth concern the night and the wallet. The fifth is the condition for the other four, because arrival points, evening districts and beds all need land that someone can plan and deliver.

Scores use only published terms found in our research to 2026. A test with no published evidence scores zero and is marked not verified, which is itself an argument for publishing. The scorecard measures the instruments a site has in place. It does not judge conservation or the quality of management.

SCORES

Petra and Diriyah pass most of the tests, and Giza scores full marks on arrival and evening hours

EXHIBIT 16

Spend Capture Scorecard: 14 heritage sites scored on five tests

Score per test from 0 to 2 (total out of 10), from published terms to 2026. Navy: 2; blue-grey: 1; sand: 0; n/v: not verified, scored 0

SITE	GATEWAY MODEL	ARRIVAL	HOURS	NIGHT	LINK	LAND	SCORE /10
Petra	Gateway town	**2** Visitor centre; Wadi Musa c.3.7 km	**2** Petra by Night	**2** JD 90 / JD 50; Jordan Pass	**1** E-carts: 75% to local owners	**2** Regional authority with socio-economic remit	9
At-Turaif, Diriyah	Planned district	**2** Bujairi Terrace; 1,700-space car park	**2** 10:00 to midnight	**0** None found	**2** Ticket spendable at Bujairi	**2** 14 km² masterplan; buffer 8.3x	8
Machu Picchu	Gateway town	**1** Aguas Calientes, bus road	n/v Not verified	**2** 1,000 tickets a day sold in district	**0** None found	**2** Buffer larger than property	5
Angkor	Gateway city	**1** Siem Reap adjacent	**1** 05:00 to 18:30	**1** 1, 3 and 7-day passes	**0** None found	**2** APSARA; zoning decree 1994	5
Uluru-Kata Tjuta	Gateway town	**2** Beds and airport outside park	n/v Not verified	**1** Three-day pass	**0** None found	**2** Joint management; services kept outside	5
Giza plateau	Arrival centre	**2** Highway entrance; 1,200 cars, 300 buses	**2** Sound and light shows daily	**0** None found	**0** None found	**1** Buffer being defined; plateau master plan under way	5
Chichen Itza	Regional day trip	**1** Road via adjacent Pisté	**2** Evening light show, Tuesday to Sunday	**0** Single visit	**1** State fee 85% of ticket	**1** Site management plan	5
Acropolis	City	**1** Museum about 300 m away	**1** 08:00 to 20:00	**0** Single visit	**0** None found	**2** Buffer 38x; strict urban rules	4
Hegra	Planned county	**2** Winter Park; 45-seat buses	n/v Not verified	**0** Single tour	**0** None found	**2** Buffer 1.0x; RCU county	4
Grand Egyptian Museum	Arrival campus	**2** 50 ha campus beside the plateau	**1** To 21:00 two days	**0** Single visit	**0** None found	**0** Outside the inscribed property	3
Pompeii	City day trip	**0** None found	**0** 09:00 to 19:00	**1** Three-day pass	**0** None found	**2** Buffer 18x	3
Stonehenge	Arrival centre	**2** Visitor centre 2.4 km	**0** 09:30 to 17:00	**0** All-day ticket	**0** None found	**1** Road harms setting (UNESCO)	3
Karnak and Valley of the Kings	River and city	**0** None found	**2** Sound and light nightly	**0** Single visit	**0** None found	**1** Plan in preparation; Avenue of Sphinxes to be added	3
Taj Mahal	City day trip	**0** None found	**0** Sunrise to sunset	**0** Three-hour limit	**0** None found	**1** Pollution-control zone	1

Source: Heirstone analysis of the Heirstone Heritage Site Benchmark 2026; test definitions on page 18. GEM hours from Enterprise (November 2025); Giza and Karnak hours from Misr Company for Sound, Light and Tourism Development (2026); Chichen Itza's Noches de Kukulkán from México Desconocido and INAH; Chichen Itza arrival and land from INAH and UNESCO; Giza land score from UNESCO's record of work on a buffer zone and the Giza Plateau Master Plan.

Arrival is where investment has gone. Seven of the 14 sites score full marks on it, and Giza's new entrance, with parking for 1,200 cars and 300 buses, is one of the largest arrival schemes in the set.

The night test separates the sites. Only Petra and Machu Picchu make the ticket depend on staying or buying locally, and both have gateway towns that live on it. Angkor, Pompeii and Uluru sell multi-day passes. Nine sites offer neither.

The highest scores come from single bodies. Petra's regional authority has a remit beyond the park, and Diriyah Company plans the district around At-Turaif. At Giza three bodies share the visitor's day: the ministry, a private operator and the Grand Egyptian Museum's board. Giza scores full marks on arrival and hours; the night and link tests would need a ticket shared across the three, and land scores one while the buffer zone and plateau master plan are prepared.



CHAPTER 6

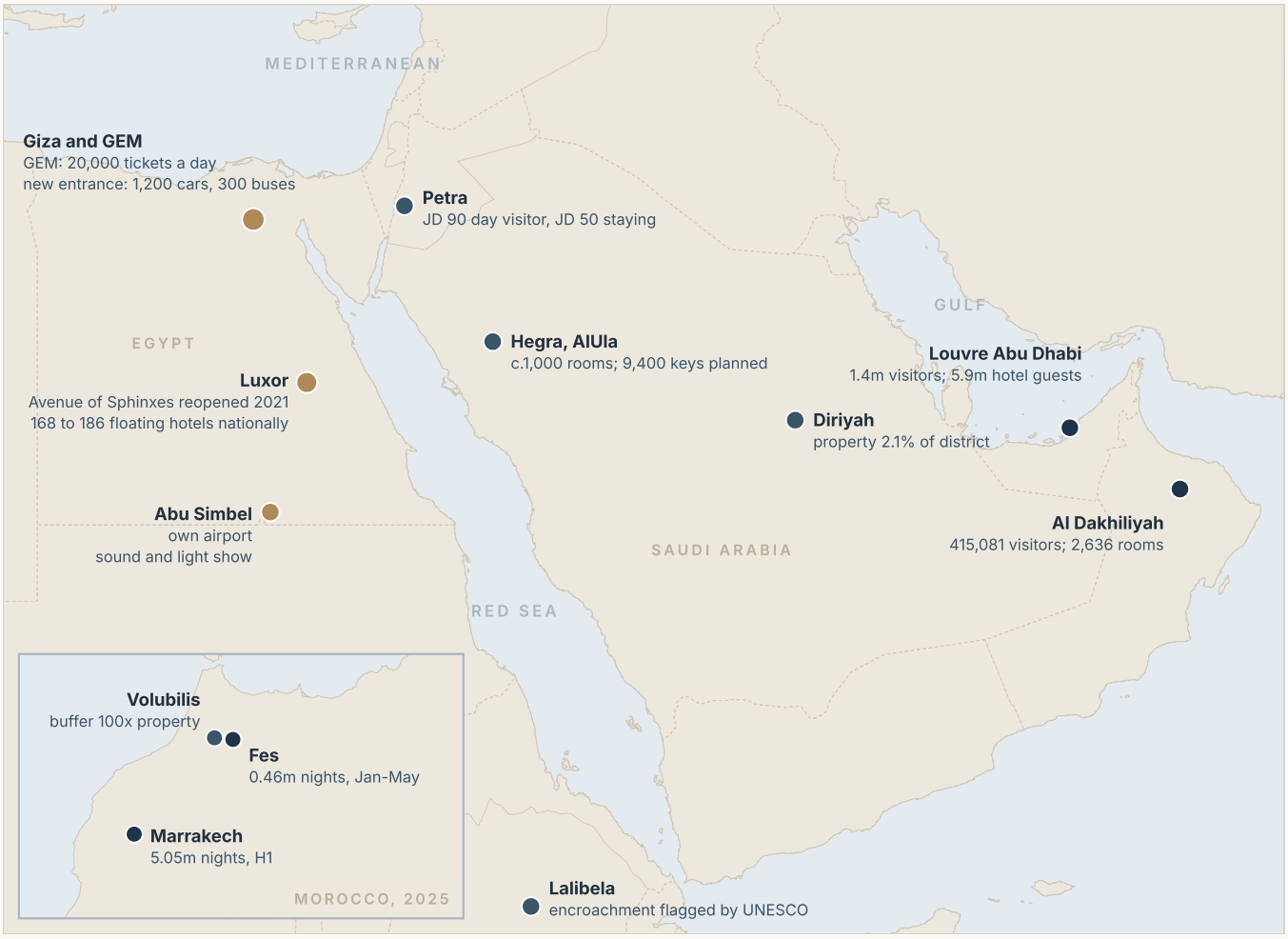
06 Egypt, Saudi Arabia and the wider region

The region holds some of the world's most visited heritage and two contrasting approaches to the land around it. Egypt has invested at the gate and in arrival, around very large properties. Saudi Arabia is planning whole districts around small cores. Jordan prices the night, Morocco's cities show what a bed base does for heritage spending, and Abu Dhabi has placed a museum inside an established hotel market.

EXHIBIT 17

Heritage anchors across the region, and the land or pricing feature that matters at each

Selected sites, with the key figure from this report; Morocco shown in the inset



Source: Heirstone Heritage Site Benchmark 2026; UNESCO World Heritage Centre and GeoNames (positions); DCT Abu Dhabi (April 2026); Moroccan Tourism Observatory via Hespress (2025); Oman Ministry of Heritage and Tourism via Muscat Daily (March 2025). Positions of Marrakech, Fes and Al Dakhiliyah (Nizwa) approximate.

EGYPT

Egypt: a record 19 million arrivals in 2025, and a third more visits to its sites and museums

Egypt received about 19 million international arrivals in 2025, a record and 21% more than in 2024. Its archaeological sites and museums recorded about 18.6 million visits, 33.5% more than in 2024, and that total excludes the Grand Egyptian Museum and the National Museum of Egyptian Civilization. That is close to one site visit for every arrival, although the visits include Egyptians.

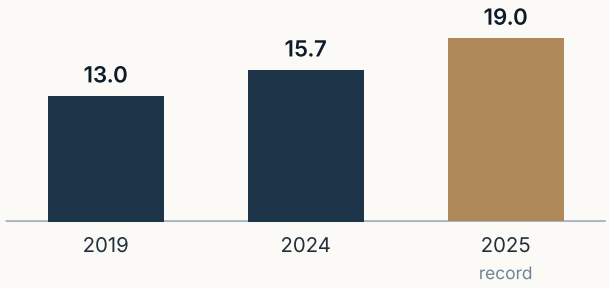
Receipts have grown with arrivals. Tourism revenue reached a record US$16.7bn in the 2024/25 fiscal year, against US$15.3bn in calendar 2024 on the ministry's figures. On our calculation, that is about US$975 per arrival in 2024. Raising what each visitor spends, by giving visitors reasons to stay near the sites, is the lever this report examines.

The government targets 30 million arrivals a year by 2028, as restated by the minister in December 2025 and January 2026. Egypt had 222,716 hotel rooms, conventional and floating, in the first quarter of 2024, after adding 4,012 in that quarter, and runs an EGP 50bn subsidised loan programme for hotel building.

EXHIBIT 18

Egypt's international arrivals reached a record 19 million in 2025, 46% more than in 2019

International tourist arrivals in Egypt, millions



Source: UN Tourism via World Bank WDI (2019); Egypt Ministry of Tourism and Antiquities via Ecofin (2024 and 2025); Egypt Independent (May 2026) for the record. Growth since 2019 is **Heirstone analysis.**

Giza: the state and a private operator share the plateau's revenue

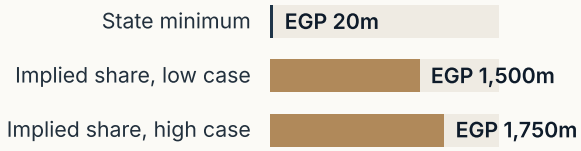
The Ministry of Tourism and Antiquities manages the plateau. Orascom Pyramids Entertainment has run visitor services since 2018 under a 15-year contract, on a 50-50 revenue share with a state minimum of EGP 20m a year. The company expects the plateau to generate EGP 3bn to 3.5bn of revenue in 2026, growing 20% to 25% a year, and targets 5 million visitors a year, which it describes as double the current number. It plans a further EGP 500m of investment in 2027, taking its total to about EGP 2bn.

In April 2025 a new entrance on the Fayoum Highway, south of the pyramids, began trial operation. It was designed for 1,200 cars and 300 buses, with a welcome centre for shops, cafés and a cinema, and more than 45 electric buses run at five-minute intervals. According to Egyptian Streets, about 2,000 horse and camel operators were moved to new zones on the plateau.

EXHIBIT 19

If the 50-50 share covers all the revenue expected in 2026, the state would receive EGP 1.5bn to 1.75bn, above a minimum of EGP 20m

Giza plateau visitor-services concession, EGP millions a year



Source: Enterprise (29 June 2026); Egyptian Streets (December 2024). Implied share is 50% of the EGP 3bn to 3.5bn the operator expects the plateau to generate in 2026; the published terms do not state the revenue base. **Heirstone analysis.**

The revenue share, which rises with visitors, carries the state's return. A floor indexed to visitor numbers would protect it if volumes fell.

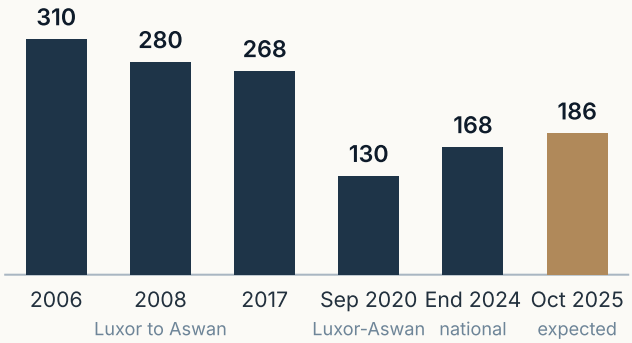
EGYPT, CONTINUED

Many of Luxor's nights are spent afloat. At Giza, two new gateways frame the land between.

EXHIBIT 20

The Nile fleet is growing again, with 18 new floating hotels expected in October 2025

Nile floating hotels, number of vessels, as reported; scope differs by source



Source: Journal of Advanced Engineering Trends citing the Floating Hotels Association (2006) and Hader (2017); Egypt Independent (September 2020); Al Arabiya Business quoting the Egyptian Hotel Chamber (October 2025; 186 expected that month).

16.7 km

of riverbank for 186 vessels moored in a single row at 90 m each

134 hours

moored on a Luxor-Aswan round trip, against 17 hours cruising

Ancient Thebes is Egypt's second great heritage property: 7,390.16 ha and twelve major archaeological sites, with a buffer of 443.55 ha. Since November 2021 the 2.7 km Avenue of Sphinxes, lined with 1,057 statues, has again linked Karnak and Luxor temples, and Egypt is working to bring it inside the property boundary.

Much of Luxor's accommodation floats. Up to 310 floating hotels with 26,700 beds operated between Luxor and Aswan in 2006. When cruises restarted in September 2020, Luxor and Aswan had 130, of which 30 to 50 were expected to sail at first. The Egyptian Hotel Chamber counted 168 at the end of 2024 and expected 186 in October 2025. In 2023 the chief executive of a Luxor hotel developer put the city's supply at about 150 tourist ships against about 25 four- and five-star land hotels.

Each vessel needs about 90 m of riverbank to moor in a single row. On a Luxor-Aswan round trip it cruises for about 17 hours and is moored for about 134. Passengers sleep and eat on board, so the riverside towns where they moor have room to capture more of their evening spending.

The Grand Egyptian Museum

The museum opened formally on 1 November 2025 about 2 km from the pyramids, on a 50 ha site with 81,000 m² of permanent galleries; Egyptian press have put its cost at more than US$1bn. It sells up to 20,000 tickets a day online in timed slots, and reported daily averages range from 19,000 (the Cabinet spokesman, November 2025) to more than 12,000 (the minister, December 2025).

Two arrival investments now sit side by side in western Giza: the museum and the plateau's new entrance, south of the pyramids.

The land that could hold the evenings and nights between them lies outside the inscribed property, and the buffer zone being delineated for Memphis and its Necropolis can frame it. Hotels are following: in April 2026 the IFC disclosed a proposed US$66.3m loan for a 400-key hotel overlooking the museum and the pyramids. Defining that land, and what it may hold, will set how much of the museum's and the plateau's visitor spending stays in Giza.

Further south, Abu Simbel has its own airport. The ten Nubian monuments from Abu Simbel to Philae cover 374.48 ha, with a protected area set by ministerial decision under the antiquities law; Abu Simbel and Philae also stage sound and light shows.

SAUDI ARABIA

Saudi Arabia is planning districts before the crowds arrive, and delivery has lagged the early targets

Diriyah: a small core in a large district

At-Turaif, inscribed in 2010, covers 28.78 ha with a buffer of 237.95 ha. Around it Diriyah Company is building a 14 km² district with a budget above SAR 236bn (US$63.2bn): 40 hotels, more than 300 branded residences, over 1.6 million m² of offices and 566,000 m² of retail. The World Heritage property is 2.1% of the masterplan area, or 19% with its buffer. The Samhan car park holds 1,700 cars and the Diriyah Square basement is designed for 10,500.

The district started with the evening. At-Turaif and Bujairi Terrace opened at the end of 2022, the terrace with more than 20 restaurants and cafés, and the access ticket can be spent in them. Together they had received 3.6 million visits by mid-2025, about 1.4 million a year. The development authority has cited a target of 27 million visitors a year (one trade report gives up to 50 million by 2030), and completion has moved from 2027 to 2030. Reaching that figure will depend on residents, offices and events as much as on heritage.

AlUla: a whole county around Hegra

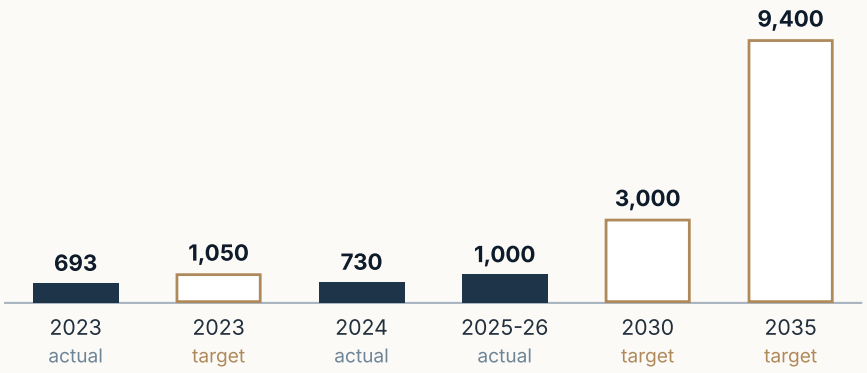
The Royal Commission for AlUla, created in 2017, governs 22,561 km² around Hegra, a 1,621.2 ha property with a buffer of 1,659.34 ha; Hegra is less than 0.1% of the county. Its Journey Through Time masterplan (2021) organises a 20 km core into five districts, with a 46 km tramway, 15 new cultural assets and 9,400 hotel keys by 2035.

Delivery has been slower. AlUla had 693 rooms in three hotels in 2023 against a target of 1,050, and about 1,000 rooms in seven hotels by 2025-26. Visits rose from 286,259 in 2024 to about 320,000 in 2025, and 72% of 2024 visitors were Saudi. The 2030 targets have been restated at 1 million visitors and about 3,000 rooms; earlier statements cited 1.2 million and 2 million. Reaching 1 million from 320,000 by 2030 needs growth of about 26% a year. The 2035 plan assumes about 213 visitors a year per key, against about 392 visits per room in 2024.

EXHIBIT 21

AlUla's room supply is about a tenth of its 2035 plan

AlUla hotel rooms or keys: actual (navy) and target (gold outline)



Source: AGBI giga-project tracker (2023-24); Skift (June 2026); Argaam (January 2024); Royal Commission for AlUla masterplan (2021). The 2030 room target was 5,000 in the January 2024 statement.

2.1%

of Diriyah's 14 km² masterplan is the At-Turaif property

72%

of AlUla's 2024 visitors were Saudi

c.26%

annual growth needed to reach 1 million AlUla visitors by 2030, from 320,000 in 2025

THE UAE, JORDAN, MOROCCO, OMAN AND AFRICA

Elsewhere in the region, the size of the nearby bed base shapes what heritage visitors spend

The UAE: a museum inside a hotel market

Louvre Abu Dhabi received about 1.4 million visitors in 2025. Abu Dhabi had 5.9 million hotel guests that year, with an average stay of 2.9 nights and 81% occupancy, so the museum′s visitors equal about 24% of the emirate′s hotel guests. The emirate counted 26.6 million visitors and 8.6 million visits to its cultural sites and libraries.

The model is a cultural anchor placed where beds already exist. Bilbao, the usual reference for museum-led regeneration, gives a benchmark: the Guggenheim′s own study credits it with EUR 676.7m of Basque GDP in 2025, about EUR 519 per visitor, on attendance that has held at 1.30 to 1.32 million for three years.

Jordan: the night priced, the year exposed

Petra combines the region′s clearest stay-capture tariff (page 10) with its sharpest swing in demand (page 17). Jordan earned about US$1,262 per international arrival in 2019, second only to the UAE among six regional markets on UN Tourism data.

Morocco: two medinas, two bed bases

Marrakech recorded 5.05 million overnight stays in classified hotels in the first half of 2025, at 71% occupancy. Fes recorded 461,201 from January to May, about 11% of Marrakech′s 4.27 million over the same months, with 51% occupancy in May. Volubilis, a 42 ha Roman site in a 4,200 ha buffer beside the pilgrimage town of Moulay Idriss Zerhoun, has no visitor figures that we could find. Morocco received 19.8 million arrivals in 2025, including Moroccans resident abroad, and targets 26 million by 2030.

Oman: heritage in the interior

Heritage and tourism sites in Al Dakhiliyah, including Nizwa, Bahla and Jabrin, received 415,081 visitors in 2024, up 33%, served by 158 hotel establishments with about 2,636 rooms: about 157 visitors per room.

Africa

South of the Sahara the evidence is thinner. UNESCO reports encroachment on Lalibela′s rock-hewn churches from new building and tourism infrastructure. Robben Island charges international visitors ZAR 600 and South Africans ZAR 400 for a tour that includes the ferry, with four departures a day, and its buffer is a nautical mile of sea.

24%

Louvre Abu Dhabi's 1.4 million visitors as a share of Abu Dhabi's 5.9 million hotel guests, 2025

EUR 519

Basque GDP per Guggenheim Bilbao visitor, 2025, on the museum's own impact study

11%

Fes hotel nights as a share of Marrakech's, January to May 2025

157

visitors per hotel room in Oman's Al Dakhiliyah heritage region, 2024

All four figures are Heirstone analysis of the sources named in the text and in the notes.

CHAPTER 7

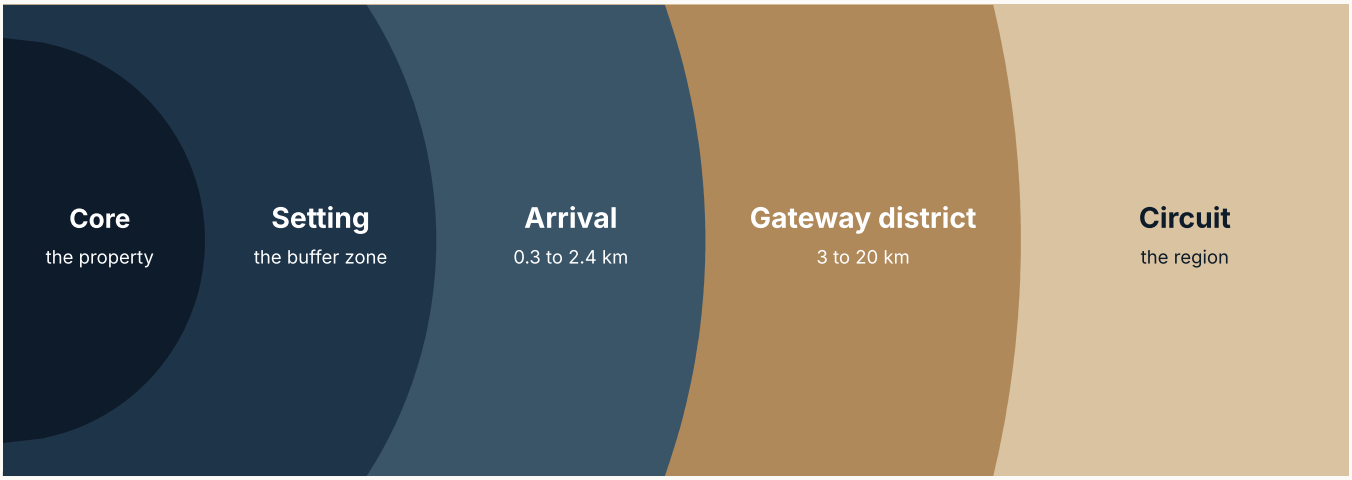
07 What the land should hold

The evidence points to a sequence for the land around a heritage site, ring by ring, from the protected core out to the region. The distances are those found in our benchmark; each site needs its own.

EXHIBIT 22

Five rings around a heritage core, and what each should hold

Heirstone framework, with supporting evidence from the Heirstone Heritage Site Benchmark 2026



Core	Setting	Arrival	Gateway district	Circuit
Should hold	**Should hold**	**Should hold**	**Should hold**	**Should hold**
Conservation and interpretation	Views and walking routes	Car and coach parks, ticketing	Evening dining and events first	Satellite sites on multi-day passes
Timed entry and daily caps	Low-rise, low-intensity uses	Welcome centre, shuttle depot	Rooms in phases, sized for a bad year	Airport and rail links
No commercial building	No towers, bridges or stadia	Cafés, shops, interpretation	Homes, schools and services	Second and third days
Evidence	**Evidence**	**Evidence**	**Evidence**	**Evidence**
20,000-a-day caps at Pompeii, Acropolis, GEM	Acropolis buffer 38x the property	Acropolis Museum 300 m; GEM 2 km; Stonehenge 2.4 km	Wadi Musa 3.7 km; AlUla 20 km from Hegra	Angkor satellites earn 2.1% of its revenue
75 minutes in the Colosseum	Liverpool and Dresden delisted over large schemes	Giza: 1,200 cars, 300 buses	Bujairi: 1m visitors in 6 months	AlUla 46 km tram; Petra JD 5 second day

Source: Heirstone analysis; evidence as cited in Chapters 1 to 6. Ring widths are schematic.

Two rules follow from the evidence. The first is order. The arrival point is usually the first piece of land a site authority controls and the first that visitors use, so it should be planned as the front door of the gateway district, with the plots around it reserved for the evening uses that keep visitors in the area. Diriyah built the restaurants of Bujairi Terrace before its hotels; they drew a million visitors in six months.

The second is restraint in the setting. The two deletions from the World Heritage List in our sample followed large schemes inside the inscribed area, a development scheme at Liverpool and a four-lane bridge at Dresden. Commercial intensity belongs on the arrival side of the access route, away from the views that the buffer zone protects.

WHAT TO DO

Plan and price the land around a heritage site for evenings and nights, and use the gate's controls to send time into it

FOR

Governments, land agencies and tourism authorities

1. Draw the buffer and the permitted uses together.
As Egypt delineates a buffer for Memphis and its Necropolis, settle what the surrounding land may hold in the same exercise.

2. Turn the foreign premium into a reward for staying.
Petra's JD 90 and JD 50 tariff and the Jordan Pass show how a foreign premium can buy a night.

3. Publish visits, nights and spending by site.
Stonehenge reports to the visit, and Egypt publishes a national total for its sites and museums. Site-level counts would let gateway districts be sized directly.

4. Index concession floors to visitors.
At Giza a 50-50 revenue share carries the state's return; a floor indexed to visitors would protect it if volumes fell.

FOR

Master developers

1. Plan the arrival point as the first plot.
Car parks and shuttle depots set the commercial map: 1,200 cars and 300 buses at Giza's new entrance, 1,700 at Diriyah's Samhan.

2. Open the evening before the hotels.
Bujairi Terrace drew a million visitors in six months with more than 20 restaurants; At-Turaif opens until midnight.

3. Phase rooms on measured nights.
Petra lost 61% of its visitors in 2024. AlUla delivered 66% of its 2023 room target.

4. Design for domestic visitors and residents.
Saudis were 72% of AlUla's 2024 visitors; Cambodians outnumbered foreigners six to one at Siem Reap Angkor in 2023.

FOR

Investors and lenders

1. Underwrite nights per visit.
Pompeii's 4.27 million visits exceed all overnight stays in Naples. Gate footfall is a weak guide to hotel demand.

2. Stress-test single-site gateways.
Model a 60% fall in a year, as at Petra, and a lasting loss of share, as at Angkor, from 44% to 15% of national arrivals.

3. Read the concession before the plot.
Term, revenue share, floor, and who controls arrival land and opening hours decide what a site-side asset can earn.

4. Look for the night instruments.
Sites that score 2 on the night test, such as Petra and Machu Picchu, direct demand to their gateway towns by design.

FOR

Site operators

1. Use caps and slots to send time into the district.
Pompeii sells 75% of its capacity before 13:00; Machu Picchu reserves 1,000 tickets a day for sale in its town.

2. Open later.
Nine of the 13 benchmark sites with published hours close by 19:00.

3. Make the ticket spendable outside the gate.
Diriyah's access ticket is redeemable in Bujairi's cafés and restaurants.

4. Bundle satellites into multi-day passes.
Koh Ker and Chong Kneas together earn the equivalent of 2.1% of Angkor's ticket revenue.

How Heirstone works on heritage destinations

We help land agencies, tourism authorities, developers and investors decide what the land around a cultural or natural asset should hold and what it is worth: demand and visitor studies, highest-and-best-use and site selection, feasibility and business models (DCF, IRR, NPV and Monte Carlo testing), masterplanning and phasing strategy, destination and economic-impact studies, and benchmarking of the kind in this report.

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NOTES, SOURCES AND DEFINITIONS

Notes

Definitions

Property: the area inscribed on the World Heritage List, also called the core. **Buffer zone:** the surrounding area with planning controls registered with UNESCO. **Buffer ratio:** buffer zone area divided by property area. **Gateway town:** the settlement that hosts most of a site's accommodation. **Receipts per arrival:** international tourism receipts divided by international arrivals. **Foreign premium multiple:** foreign adult ticket divided by the national adult ticket. **Overnight stays:** nights spent in accommodation (presenze in Italian statistics). Visits and visitors are as published; some sources count entries, others people.

Method

Figures are as published by the sources listed, in the currency and period stated. We have not converted currencies, except Saudi riyals at the official rate of SAR 3.75 per US dollar and US dollar equivalents given by the source itself. Where we derive a figure (per visitor, per resident, per room, ratios and shares) it is labelled Heirstone analysis and uses only the published inputs shown with it. Where sources conflict we show the range or the more conservative figure and say so. Ticket prices from a single travel guide or tour operator are marked. The Spend Capture Scorecard scores each test 0, 1 or 2 from published terms; tests with no published evidence score zero and are marked not verified. Historic Jeddah (Saudi Arabia) and Al Ain (UAE) were within scope, but we found no published visitor, ticket or room figures comparable with the benchmark, so they are not scored.

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Use of this report

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CHAPTER 1

UNESCO World Heritage Centre, World Heritage List (2025); Italian Ministry of Culture via Finestre sull'Arte (May 2025), 9colonne (May 2025) and Geopop; ISTAT, I flussi turistici, anno 2024 (March 2026); Parco Archeologico di Pompei, timetables and tickets (2026); Euronews (December 2018); AP (July 2024, April 2025); The Palace Museum (2026); Xinhua citing Beijing Evening News (December 2019); Travel News (September 2023) and AP via WHDH and Boston Globe (2023); The New Arab (November 2025); Andina (2025); Parco archeologico del Colosseo (2026); L'Echo touristique with AFP (January 2025, January 2026); India Ministry of Tourism, India Tourism Data Compendium 2025, via PTI (September 2025); Business Today citing the Archaeological Survey of India (June 2019); Experience AlUla (2026); Bujairi/Diriyah Company ticketing (2026); Saudipedia, Bujairi Terrace; Horwath HTL, Siem Reap (September 2024); Enterprise (November 2025); Misr Company for Sound, Light and Tourism Development (2026); operators' published timetables.

CHAPTER 2

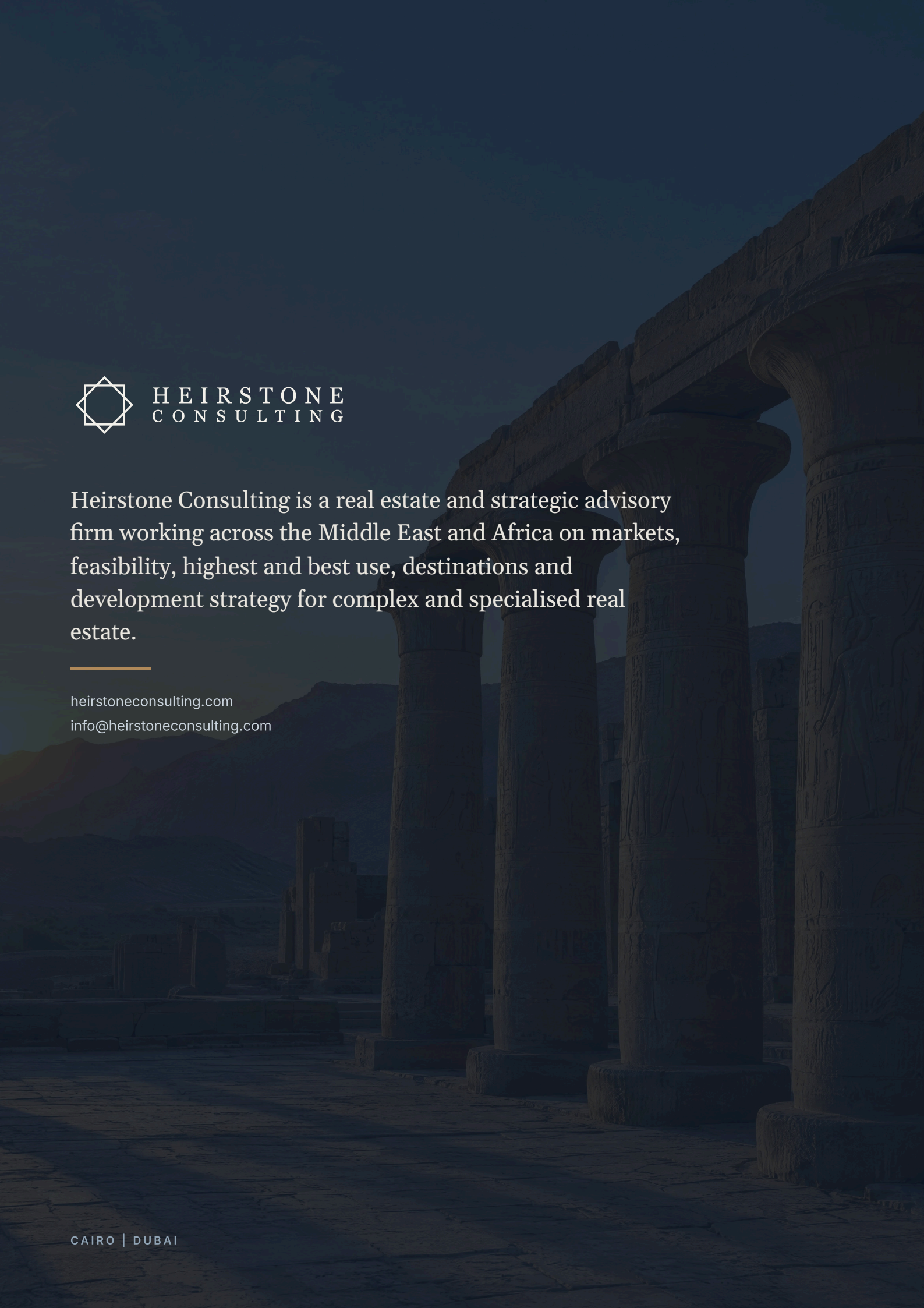
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CHAPTERS 3 AND 4

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CHAPTERS 5 TO 7

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